

Chapter 15

Character Strengths Use and Human Flourishing in Adolescence and Youth



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Abstract The chapter examines the relationship between the use of character strengths and human flourishing in Mexican university students. Conducted with 7407 students from Universidad Tecmilenio, this correlational study utilized validated instruments, such as Diener's Human Flourishing Scale and a brief version of the Strengths Use Scale adapted to Spanish. The findings reveal that students who more frequently use their strengths report higher levels of human flourishing. The study highlights gender differences: women excel in the use of vitality, while men show higher performance in creativity and leadership. This underscores the importance of considering cultural and demographic factors when fostering strengths. It concludes that promoting the conscious use of strengths in educational contexts could enhance students' overall well-being. The study recommends exploring this relationship in other cultural and workplace settings, as well as developing personalized programs to maximize the impact of specific strengths. This approach could transform education and contribute to healthier and more prosperous societies.

Keywords Human flourishing · Character strengths · Youth

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15.1 Introduction

In recent decades, positive psychology has emerged as a prominent field of study, focused on exploring the factors that contribute to human well-being, happiness, and flourishing (Waters et al., 2021). Within this framework, the concept of character strengths has garnered considerable attention, and is recognized as a foundational pillar for developing a full and satisfying life (Lavy, 2020). Character strengths, defined as positive psychological traits reflected in thoughts, feelings, and behaviors, play a critical role in promoting human flourishing—an optimal state of well-being characterized by the experience of positive emotions, engagement, meaningful relationships, a virtuous life and a meaningful life.

Building on this foundation, the current study is inspired by the growing evidence suggesting a significant relationship between the active use of personal character strengths and human flourishing (Lavy et al., 2017; Niemiec, 2019). Prior research, such as that conducted by Govindji and Linley (2007), has begun to unravel how the identification and conscious application of personal strengths can improve wellbeing and human flourishing. However, despite these advances, significant gaps remain in our understanding of how leveraging character strengths facilitate flourishing across different contexts and populations. This study focuses on a group of students at Tecmilenio University, an institution whose educational model emphasizes promoting well-being using recent positive education framework. These students, having taken the VIA Test to identify their character strengths, constitute an ideal population for investigating the impact of strengths utilization. Some studies focus on the instruments for measuring character strengths (Peterson & Seligman, 2004; Russo-Netzer et al., 2023; Toner et al., 2012), and some others on measuring their actual use (Bakker & van Wingerden, 2020; Govindji & Linley, 2007). This research will be focused in the second option.

15.2 Theoretical Framework

15.2.1 *What Are Character Strengths*

This study aims to expand existing knowledge by exploring character strengths utilization and human flourishing in Mexican adolescents. While positive psychology has gained substantial global attention a need for more research within the Latin American context. Most studies have concentrated on populations in the United States, Australia, and Europe (O'Connor & Cameron, 2017). This article could significantly contribute to the body of knowledge on positive psychology in Latin America, providing unique perspectives and enriching the global dialogue on human well-being.

Character strengths have been linked to enhanced motivation and academic engagement. Research by Lavy and Littman-Ovadia (2017) have shown that the

application of character strengths in the educational field can impact positively on academic performance. Additionally, recognizing and using these strengths can substantially improve interpersonal relationships in the university environment (Charles-Leijja & Toledo, 2021). Research by Peterson and Park (2006) suggests that strengths such as kindness and leadership promote more positive and collaborative relationships. University education prepares students not only academically but also for their professional lives. Character strengths, according to studies like Harzer and Ruch (2015), can improve adaptability and, key skills in the workplace. Students who use their strengths are better prepared to contribute to society. According to studies such as Peterson et al. (2005), these individuals show greater empathy and social responsibility, and are more willing to participate in community activities. While prior studies, such as Eksi et al. (2022), have explored the relationship between human flourishing and character strengths using a Turkish version of the VIA inventory, they primarily measure the type of strengths an individual possesses rather than their daily use. The classification of character strengths was generated, in the early twenty-first century, in response to a need identified by the Mayerson Foundation, regarding the limitations and slow progress of traditional problem-solving approaches. Neal Mayerson and Martin Seligman explored the intersection between positive youth development and emerging positive psychology (Peterson & Seligman, 2004). Two crucial questions arose: how to define the concepts of “strength” and “maximum potential” and how to evaluate the success of a positive youth development program. To address these challenges, the Values in Action (VIA) Institute was created, with the aim of developing a scientific knowledge base on human strengths. Peterson and Seligman, along with a team of experts, worked for three years developing a classification system of human strengths and virtue and creating methods for their measurement (Peterson & Seligman, 2004).

The 24 strengths classified by Peterson and Seligman (2004) are grouped into six values:

1. Wisdom and knowledge: creativity, curiosity, open-mindedness, love of learning, and perspective.
2. Courage: Courage, persistence, integrity, vitality.
3. Humanity: love, kindness, and social intelligence.
4. Justice: citizenship, fairness and leadership.
5. Temperance: forgiveness, humility, prudence, and self-regulation.
6. Transcendence: appreciation of beauty, gratitude, hope, humor and spirituality.

15.2.2 Description of Character Strengths

From this foundation, a classification of 24-character strengths was developed, which are outlined below:

1. Creativity: Thinking of new and productive ways to do things; includes artistic creativity but extends to any area of life.

2. Curiosity: Interest in experience and exploration of new ideas, discoveries, and knowledge acquisition.
3. Judgment: Thinking rationally and logically about all things; considering all facets before making decisions.
4. Love of learning: Having a deep desire to learn and continue developing throughout life.
5. Perspective: Being able to provide wise and helpful advice to others; having a big picture view.
6. Bravery: Not backing down from a threat, challenge, difficulty, or pain; acting with conviction despite fear.
7. Perseverance: Finishing what one starts; persisting in a task until completion, despite obstacles.
8. Honesty: Being sincere and authentic in what one does; being responsible and genuine.
9. Zest: Facing life with excitement and energy; feeling and showing enthusiasm.
10. Love: Valuing close relationships with others, especially those in which affection and care are mutual.
11. Kindness: Doing favors and good deeds for others; helping and caring for others.
12. Social intelligence: Being aware of one's own and others' motives and feelings; knowing how to adapt to different social situations.
13. Citizenship or teamwork: Working well as a member of a group or team; being loyal to the group.
14. Fairness: Treating all people according to principles of justice and equity; giving each person the opportunity to succeed.
15. Leadership: Encouraging a group of which one is a member to achieve its goals; organizing and managing group activities.
16. Forgiveness: Being indulgent and giving second chances; not holding grudges.
17. Humility: Not seeking to be the center of attention; letting achievements speak for themselves.
18. Prudence: Being careful with decisions; not taking unnecessary risks.
19. Self-control: Regulating what one feels and does; being disciplined.
20. Appreciation of beauty and excellence: Noticing and appreciating beauty, excellence, and/or talented performance in various domains of life.
21. Gratitude: Being aware and thankful for the good things that happen; taking time to express gratitude.
22. Hope: Expecting the best and working to achieve it; believing that a good future is something that can be achieved.
23. Humor: Liking to laugh and joke; bringing smiles to others; seeing the positive side of life.
24. Spirituality: Having coherent beliefs about the higher purpose and meaning of the universe; knowing where one fits within a larger scheme.

15.2.3 *Human Flourishing: The Elements Considered by Ed Diener*

Various researchers have addressed the topic of well-being and human flourishing, with Ed Diener recognized as one of the most prolific individuals in this field. In the 1980s, Diener developed the most widely used instrument worldwide for measuring subjective well-being (Diener et al., 1985), and in recent years, he introduced a scale to measure human flourishing (Diener et al., 2010).

15.2.3.1 What Is Human Flourishing

Human flourishing (HF) is a recurring concept throughout the history of civilization and has been approached from various disciplines, such as economics, political philosophy, moral philosophy, and psychology (Silveyra et al., 2021). In the context of this article, human flourishing refers to the ability of individuals to reach their maximum potential in life. This implies achieving the goods, purposes, and ultimate goals of human existence, a state of living a life in which most aspects of a person's life are good and thriving. Human flourishing is thus understood as living within an optimal range of human functionality.

Research links the concept of human flourishing to dimensions of human functioning, such as personal relationships, purpose and meaning in life, mastery of the environment, happiness and life satisfaction, as well as the experience of positive emotions (Ryff, 1989). Among the elements that make up human flourishing, a sense of good life, personal relationships, autonomy, purpose, and optimism are emphatically included (Ryff, 2019). In many ways, it can be said that the constant use of character strengths can impact human flourishing, as it affects the elements that comprise it.

15.2.3.2 Meaning in Life

Character strengths are qualities that not only shape our daily interactions and achievements but also guide us towards a deeper understanding of our place in the world and our contributions to it, meaning in life (Russo-Netzer et al., 2023). Character strengths act as internal compasses that orient our actions and decisions towards meaningful goals. One of the most evident ways in which character strengths contribute to meaning in life is through self-knowledge and authenticity. When people identify and cultivate their strengths, they develop a clearer understanding of who they are and what they value (Peterson & Seligman, 2004). This self-understanding is crucial for establishing a sense of purpose, a critical element of meaning in life, according to Russo-Netzer et al. (2023), as it allows individuals to align their goals and aspirations with their intrinsic values and talents.

Character strengths also foster resilience and perseverance, essential qualities for pursuing and maintaining a meaningful life. Facing challenges and adversities is an inevitable part of the journey towards achieving our goals. Strengths such as courage and perseverance allow individuals to overcome obstacles and stay focused on their long-term objectives (Hill et al., 2016). The strength of curiosity can foster understanding of the world, perseverance can drive goal-seeking, and gratitude can increase feelings of significance and connection to others (Russo-Netzer et al., 2023). This sustained focus not only contributes to achieving meaningful goals but also reinforces the sense of purpose, as each overcome challenge reaffirms the value and importance of personal aspirations.

Finally, the conscious use of character strengths helps people build a coherent and positive narrative about their lives. Reflecting on how strengths have influenced past experiences and how they can guide future actions allows individuals to create a life story that highlights growth, learning, and contribution. This narrative not only provides a framework for understanding the past and present but also inspires and motivates future actions aligned with a meaningful life.

15.2.3.3 Interpersonal Relationships

The connection between the use of character strengths and interpersonal relationships is profound and multifaceted, as these strengths can influence how individuals engage and relate to others and respond to social dynamics. One of the main ways in which character strengths impact interpersonal relationships is through improved communication. For example, empathy enables people to understand and identify with the feelings and emotional states of others. This ability to put oneself in another's perspective facilitates more effective communication and reduces misunderstandings. When a person shows empathy, they not only listen to others' words but also discern the emotions behind them, fostering more meaningful and authentic interactions (Telle & Pfister, 2014). This mutual understanding is fundamental to building and maintaining healthy and satisfying relationships.

Integrity, another essential character strength, also plays a crucial role in interpersonal relationships. Integrity involves being honest and having solid moral principles. People who practice integrity tend to be seen as trustworthy and reliable (Alsharo et al., 2017). Trust is the foundation of any strong relationship, whether personal or professional. When individuals act with integrity, they create an environment where others feel safe to be open and vulnerable. This openness and vulnerability are essential for forming deep and lasting bonds.

Gratitude is another strength that has a significant impact on interpersonal relationships (Bartlett & DeSteno, 2006). Expressing gratitude involves recognizing and appreciating the acts of kindness of others. This practice not only improves personal well-being by increasing feelings of happiness and satisfaction but also strengthens relationships. People who express gratitude regularly tend to have more positive relationships and fewer conflicts. Thanking others for their efforts and

support fosters an environment of reciprocity and mutual respect, which can deepen the emotional connection between people.

Humor, as a character strength, can also enrich interpersonal relationships (Carbelo & Jáuregui, 2006). Humor has the power to alleviate tensions and create a sense of camaraderie. Sharing moments of laughter can strengthen bonds between people, making them feel more connected and supported. Additionally, humor can serve as a tool for handling difficult situations and conflicts, helping people see circumstances from a different and less stressful perspective. This playful approach can defuse potential disagreements and promote more harmonious coexistence.

The strength of perseverance can also influence interpersonal relationships. Perseverance implies the ability to stay firm and move forward despite obstacles and challenges. In the context of relationships, perseverance can translate into the ability to work on problems and conflicts instead of avoiding or abandoning them. Relationships require continuous effort and commitment, and the ability to persevere in difficult times can be key to maintaining and strengthening long-term bonds.

Justice, as a character strength, manifests in fairness and fair treatment towards others. Practicing justice in interpersonal relationships involves treating everyone with respect and consideration, regardless of individual differences. This equitable approach can help build an environment of trust and mutual respect, where each person feels valued and recognized. Justice fosters a sense of community and belonging, which is essential for social well-being and cohesion.

Finally, humility is a character strength that can profoundly enrich interpersonal relationships. Humility involves having a realistic view of oneself and not constantly seeking approval or recognition from others. Humble people tend to be more open to receiving feedback and learning from others, which can improve the quality of their interactions and relationships. Humility also allows people to recognize and appreciate the strengths and contributions of others, fostering an environment of support and collaboration.

15.2.3.4 Engagement

Engagement is as an optimal state of experience where people are completely immersed and absorbed in an activity (Diener et al., 2010), is deeply related to the use of character strengths. The intersection between strengths and engagement is fundamental to understanding how people can achieve high levels of performance in various activities. When people use their character strengths, they are more likely to experience engagement due to the alignment between their innate abilities and the demands of the task.

The knowledge and utilization of one's strengths enable individuals to act more authentically and in alignment with their personal values (Peterson & Seligman, 2004). This authenticity not only increases well-being but also enhances the likelihood of reaching engagement in activities that resonate with the individual's identity and personal interests. Character strengths, being aligned with innate capacities and skills, allow people to face challenges more effectively and confidently (Wagner

et al., 2020). Engagement occurs when there is a balance between skills and challenge and people feel full of energy (Csikszentmihalyi, 2020). People who use their strengths in challenging activities not only feel more competent but are also more likely to experience engagement.

15.2.3.5 Self-Efficacy

The relationship between the use of character strengths and self-efficacy is a central theme in positive psychology, it underscores how recognizing and applying of personal strengths can significantly influence the perception of one's ability to handle situations and achieve goals. Self-efficacy, defined by Bandura (1997) as the belief in one's ability to organize and execute the actions necessary to manage future situations, is enhanced through the identification and application of character strengths. By leveraging their strengths, people experience a heightened sense of competence and confidence in their abilities, which is closely related to the concept of self-efficacy.

The use of character strengths fosters self-efficacy by providing people with direct experiences of success and achievement (Martínez-Martí & Ruch, 2017). Bandura (1997) argues that self-efficacy is built through mastery experiences, where the individual overcomes challenges and achieves their goals. For example, a person with the strength of perseverance is able to face and overcome persistent obstacles, reinforcing their belief in their ability to handle future difficulties. This cycle of success and positive reinforcement strengthens self-efficacy, making it more robust and resilient to adversity.

Additionally, the recognition and use of personal strengths are also linked to increased emotional well-being, which can positively influence self-efficacy. Fredrickson (2001) suggests that positive emotions broaden people's repertoire of thoughts and actions, fostering personal resources that include self-efficacy. When people focus on their strengths, they experience positive emotions that not only enhance their overall well-being but also increase their confidence in their abilities to face challenges.

Research also suggests that the use of character strengths can improve self-efficacy through the observation of positive models. According to Bandura (1997), self-efficacy can be increased by observing others who employ their strengths to achieve success. In educational and workplace settings, individuals can learn from the examples of other students and teachers who demonstrate how to effectively use personal strengths to achieve goals and overcome obstacles.

Another element of interest is positive feedback. Positive feedback and recognition of the use of character strengths also play a crucial role in building self-efficacy. When people receive recognition for employing their strengths, it reinforces their belief in their ability to contribute meaningfully and effectively. This positive feedback not only validates their skills but also motivates continued and conscious use of their strengths.

15.2.3.6 Virtuous Life

The relationship between the use of character strengths and a virtuous life has been a subject of reflection since the times of Aristotle and continues to be relevant in contemporary psychology. Aristotle, in his work “Nicomachean Ethics,” argues that a virtuous life is one in which individuals develop and practice virtues, thereby achieving eudaimonia or human flourishing (Aristóteles, 349 C.E.). According to Aristotle, virtues are acquired dispositions that allow people to act correctly and find a balance between the extremes of excess and deficiency. This classical view resonates with modern positive psychology, which also emphasizes the importance of identifying and cultivating character strengths to live a full and meaningful life. Aristotle considered that virtue was achieved through the practice and continuous development of positive habits. Similarly, Peterson and Seligman (2004) propose that these strengths are positive qualities that, when practiced regularly, contribute to individual well-being and flourishing. Like Aristotelian virtues, these strengths are considered essential for achieving a full and virtuous life.

15.3 Method

15.3.1 Data Collection

The study involved 7407 participants, of whom 52.8% were women and 47.2% were men. The average age was 23.3 years ($SD = 9.36$, range from 15 to 67 years). Among the participants, 35.4% were high school students, 41.4% were undergraduate students, and 23.2% were postgraduate students.

15.3.2 Instruments Used

The Human Flourishing Scale developed by Diener et al. (2010) is an assessment tool designed to measure psychological and social well-being, central aspects of human flourishing. This scale is part of a broader effort to provide brief yet comprehensive measures to assess subjective well-being. The scale consists of eight items that address important dimensions of flourishing, including meaning in life, positive social relationships, engagement, competence, self-esteem, and optimism. The items are formulated to be answered on a Likert-type scale, where participants indicate their level of agreement or disagreement with each statement, reflecting the frequency with which they experience these positive aspects in their lives. This instrument is distinguished by its brevity, ease of application, and focus on key components of well-being beyond the mere absence of distress, thus capturing a more complete view of human flourishing. The validity and reliability of the Diener

et al. Flourishing Scale have been tested in various studies (Checa et al., 2018; Duan & Xie, 2019; Giuntoli et al., 2017; Silva & Caetano, 2013; Sumi, 2014; Villieux et al., 2016), making it a valuable tool for both academic research and practical application in personal and professional development. Some examples of items from the scale are: “My social relationships are rewarding and provide me with the support I need” and “I look to the future with optimism.”

The Strengths Use Scale presented by Govindji and Linley (2007) is designed to assess how individuals apply their personal strengths in their daily lives. This instrument is based on the premise that the conscious and deliberate use of personal strengths can generate benefits in people’s lives. The general focus of the study is to measure the frequency with which individuals identify, mobilize, and employ their personal strengths in different contexts, such as work, personal relationships, and leisure activities. The scale seeks to capture the self-perception of strengths use and how this relates to self-concordance, that is, the extent to which personal activities and goals are aligned with the individual’s values and strengths. The original scale has a total of 30 items and three factors (appreciation, knowledge, and use of strengths). Original paper showed alphas between 0.89 and 0.95 for their factors, Recent validations have presented similar results (Bressoud et al., 2024; Tang et al., 2019). In this study, only four items that underwent psychometric validation by the authors are used. The selected items represent a single reference construct (use of strengths). Some examples of items from the Strengths Use Scale are: “I know my strengths well” and “I achieve what I want by using my strengths.” The instrument used was psychometrically validated in Spanish (by authors of this research), and this validation has not yet been published, but is available upon request.

15.3.3 Procedure

The study was conducted through an online survey during the last week of November 2023. The data are part of a questionnaire administered at the end of each semester to the entire student population (over 60,000 people). Students voluntarily decide whether to respond to the survey, which includes scales to measure aspects related to their well-being (only the 7000 students answered items related to character strengths use and human flourishing).

15.4 Results

Table 15.1 presents descriptive statistics for a series of variables related to the study of human flourishing and the use of character strengths. Each item, identified with a code (such as “hf1”, “hf2”, etc., for items related to human flourishing, and “cs9”, “cs14”, etc., for items related to character strengths), represents a specific variable evaluated in the study.

Table 15.1 Descriptive statistics of the study variables

Items	Mean	Standard deviation
hf1	6.71	0.87
hf2	6.18	1.17
hf3	6.22	1.17
hf4	6.16	1.16
hf5	6.45	1.03
hf6	6.39	1.05
hf7	6.33	1.23
hf8	6.29	1.13
cs9	6.17	1.22
cs14	6.05	1.27
cs20	6.07	1.29
cs23	5.99	1.34
Human flourishing	5.54	0.74
Character strength use	6.07	1.06

The items labeled from “hf1” to “hf8” represent different aspects or dimensions of human flourishing, with average scores ranging from 6.16 to 6.71. These scores suggest a relatively high level of flourishing among participants. The study participants report relatively high levels of both human flourishing and use of strengths, suggesting a positive relationship between these two areas of study.

Table 15.2 presents Pearson correlations between different items measuring aspects of human flourishing (hf) and use of strengths (cs), as well as correlations between the general factors of human flourishing (hf) and use of strengths (ucs). Items related to human flourishing (hf1 to hf8) show moderate to strong correlations with each other ($r = 0.44$ to $r = 0.67$), indicating that these aspects of human flourishing are interrelated.

Similarly, items related to the use of strengths (cs9, cs14, cs20, cs23) show moderate to strong correlations with each other ($r = 0.50$ to $r = 0.70$), indicating a consistent relationship in the use of different character strengths. The correlation between the general factors of human flourishing (hf) and use of strengths (ucs) is moderately high ($r = 0.68$), indicating a significant positive relationship between the general use of strengths and the level of human flourishing. This suggests that the use of character strengths is associated with human flourishing.

The existence of positive correlations between the use of strengths and human flourishing supports the idea that fostering the use of character strengths can be an effective strategy for promoting well-being and flourishing in individuals. The strong correlations within the groups of flourishing and strength use items suggest that these constructs are internally coherent and represent valid constructs to scrutinize in the context of subjective well-being. Table 15.2 provides valuable quantitative evidence that underscores the interconnection between the use of personal strengths and human flourishing, offering a solid foundation for future research and interventions in the fields of positive psychology and positive education.

Table 15.2 Pearson correlation of items and factors human flourishing and use of strengths

Items	hf1	hf2	hf3	hf4	hf5	hf6	hf7	hf8	cses9	cses14	cses20	cses23	hf	uf
hf1	1.00	0.45	0.50	0.44	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.45	0.34	0.32	0.32	0.31	0.70	0.39
hf2	0.45	1.00	0.57	0.56	0.47	0.55	0.51	0.53	0.45	0.43	0.44	0.43	0.76	0.53
hf3	0.50	0.57	1.00	0.56	0.59	0.57	0.61	0.53	0.44	0.48	0.47	0.45	0.81	0.56
hf4	0.44	0.56	0.56	1.00	0.52	0.57	0.49	0.49	0.45	0.42	0.43	0.42	0.76	0.52
hf5	0.52	0.47	0.59	0.52	1.00	0.63	0.58	0.52	0.42	0.45	0.43	0.38	0.77	0.50
hf6	0.52	0.55	0.57	0.57	0.63	1.00	0.67	0.60	0.47	0.48	0.46	0.43	0.76	0.56
hf7	0.52	0.51	0.61	0.49	0.58	0.67	1.00	0.60	0.46	0.52	0.52	0.45	0.81	0.59
hf8	0.45	0.53	0.53	0.49	0.52	0.60	0.60	1.00	0.53	0.47	0.48	0.43	0.77	0.58
cs9	0.34	0.45	0.44	0.45	0.42	0.47	0.46	0.53	1.00	0.57	0.57	0.50	0.57	0.79
cs14	0.32	0.43	0.48	0.42	0.45	0.48	0.52	0.47	0.57	1.00	0.70	0.55	0.58	0.85
cs20	0.32	0.44	0.47	0.43	0.43	0.46	0.52	0.48	0.57	0.70	1.00	0.59	0.58	0.87
cs23	0.31	0.43	0.45	0.42	0.38	0.43	0.45	0.43	0.50	0.55	0.59	1.00	0.53	0.80
Human flourishing	0.70	0.76	0.81	0.76	0.77	0.76	0.81	0.77	0.57	0.58	0.58	0.53	1.00	0.68
Character use	0.39	0.53	0.56	0.52	0.50	0.56	0.59	0.58	0.79	0.85	0.87	0.80	0.68	1.00

The data showed a positive and significant correlation between the frequent use of character strengths and levels of human flourishing. Participants who reported higher use of their personal strengths also reported higher levels of meaningful life, relationships, engagement, self-efficacy, and optimism.

These results underscore the importance of recognizing and applying personal character strengths to promote human flourishing. The research provides hints on how educational and psychological interventions that encourage the use of strengths can have a significant impact on student well-being.

Figure 15.1 shows a detailed view of the relationship between the level of human flourishing (X-axis) and the use of various character strengths (Y-axis). Each point on the graph represents a specific strength, labeled with its name and colored according to the value it is integrated with.

Analysis of the graph reveals that strengths such as leadership, courage, and vitality are situated in the upper right. This positioning indicates that these strengths are not only frequently used but are also highly associated with an elevated level of human flourishing. This suggests that individuals who frequently employ these strengths tend to experience greater well-being and personal fulfillment. The prominence of these strengths could be due to their capacity to drive decisive actions, face challenges, and maintain constant energy and enthusiasm in daily activities.

On the other hand, strengths such as love of learning, perseverance, and creativity, although also showing a high relationship with human flourishing, are in a slightly lower position in terms of use compared to leadership, courage, and vitality. However, their positive association on human flourishing is considerable. These strengths foster continuous growth, the ability to overcome obstacles, and the generation of innovative solutions, which significantly contribute to personal and academic well-being.

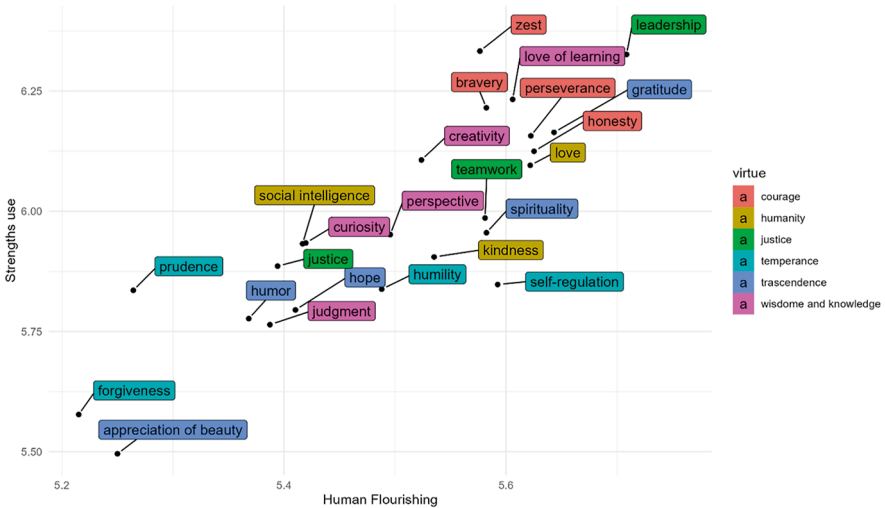


Fig. 15.1 Human flourishing and character strength use

The strengths of love, teamwork, and spirituality are located in an intermediate zone of the graph, indicating a balance between their use and the level of human flourishing they promote. These strengths are linked to the creation of solid interpersonal relationships and a deeper sense of meaningful life, which is crucial for the integral development of individuals. The constant practice of these strengths can lead to a more collaborative environment and greater social cohesion, benefiting both at the individual and the collective levels, including the classroom, or even the entire educational center.

In the lower left part of the graph are strengths such as prudence, forgiveness, and appreciation of beauty. These strengths, although valuable, seem to be used less frequently and are less associated with human flourishing compared to other strengths. This could suggest that these strengths are not necessarily less important, but that their positive impact is not as immediate or evident as that of other strengths. Promoting greater use and recognition of these strengths could potentially increase their contribution to overall well-being.

Strengths such as honesty, gratitude, and hope are located at the top of the graph, but with an intermediate level of human flourishing. This indicates that, although these strengths are frequently used, their association with human flourishing is moderate. Honesty, for example, although essential for personal and social integrity, may not always be directly correlated with an increase in subjective well-being. Similarly, gratitude and hope are fundamental to maintaining a positive attitude, but their association may be more subtle and gradual compared to the strengths located in the upper right quadrant.

Humor and judgment, situated near the center of the graph, show moderate use and level of human flourishing. These strengths, although important, seem to have a more balanced and less extreme link compared to others. Humor can improve emotional well-being and interpersonal relationships, while judgment contributes to informed and reflective decision-making.

It is particularly striking that the strengths associated with the virtue of “courage”—specifically vitality, bravery, and perseverance—are positioned at the top of the graph, both in terms of human flourishing and use of strengths. This indicates a strong and significant correlation between these characteristics and students’ personal and academic development.

Vitality, which appears at the highest point of the graph, implies approaching life with enthusiasm and energy. In the university context, this could translate into active participation in learning, a willingness to face new challenges, and a positive attitude towards educational opportunities. Bravery, another courage strength that is situated in a high position, implies the ability to face fears and challenges. In the university setting, this could manifest as the willingness to address difficult topics, express unpopular opinions, or take calculated risks in academic projects. Perseverance, also situated in a high position, reflects the ability to persist in difficult or long-term tasks. This strength is crucial in the academic environment, where long-term projects, challenging exams, and the need to maintain a good performance consistently are common. The high position of perseverance suggests that

students who can sustain their efforts and concentration over time tend to experience greater flourishing and make more effective use of their strengths.

It is interesting to note that other strengths associated with different virtues, such as leadership (related to justice) and gratitude (related to transcendence), also appear in elevated positions. This could indicate that, although courage is fundamental, a balanced approach that incorporates strengths from various virtues contributes to the overall flourishing of the student.

The prominent position of courage strengths in this graph has significant implications for higher education. It suggests that educational institutions could benefit from actively fostering these strengths in their students. This could be achieved through programs that challenge students to step out of their comfort zone, that reward persistence, and that celebrate energy and enthusiasm in learning.

Figure 15.2 presents a comparison of human flourishing and the use of character strengths differentiated by gender. Similar to the previous graph, the X-axis shows the level of human flourishing, while the Y-axis represents the use of various character strengths. The points on the graph are labeled with the names of the strengths, and the size of the points indicates the frequency or amount of use.

In the panel corresponding to the female gender, we observe that the strength of vitality is situated in the upper right, indicating that it is a strength with a high level of use and a strong association with human flourishing. This suggests that women who frequently use their vitality tend to experience greater well-being and satisfaction in their lives. Other strengths that stand out in terms of use and flourishing include leadership, love of learning, and courage. These strengths have significant connections with human flourishing, suggesting that developing these qualities can contribute importantly to personal well-being.

Figure 15.2 also reveals that strengths such as honesty, gratitude, and love are in an intermediate position, indicating moderate use and a considerable relationship with human flourishing. These strengths are fundamental for maintaining healthy

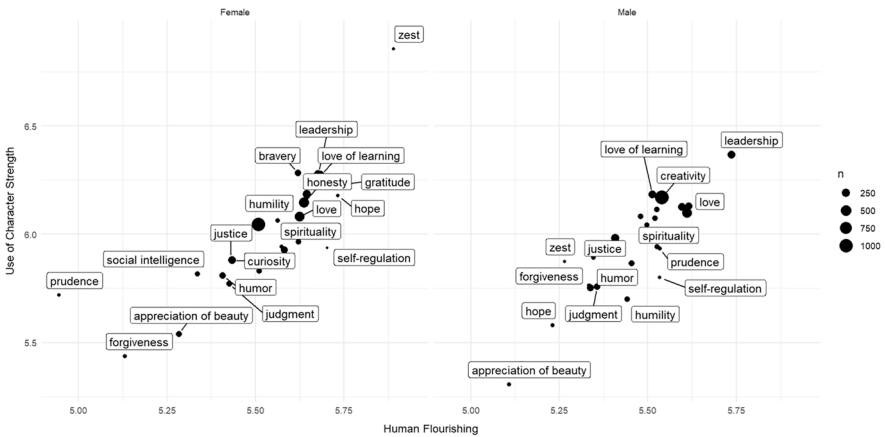


Fig. 15.2 Human flourishing and character strength use, by gender (female, left)

interpersonal relationships and a sense of personal integrity, which in turn contributes to overall well-being. Strengths such as social intelligence, justice, and humor also show a balanced relationship between their use and human flourishing, suggesting that they are valuable qualities that can be cultivated to improve individual well-being.

In the lower left part of the female graph are strengths such as forgiveness and appreciation of beauty, indicating lower use and a lower association with human flourishing. This could imply that these strengths, although important, are not recognized or practiced as frequently as others, and their connection with overall well-being is less pronounced. However, promoting greater use of these strengths could potentially increase their contribution to well-being.

In the panel corresponding to the male gender, leadership stands out as a strength with a high level of use and a strong association with human flourishing. Men who frequently employ leadership tend to experience higher levels of well-being. Other prominent strengths include creativity, love of learning, and love, which also show a significant relationship with human flourishing. These strengths seem to be especially beneficial for personal and professional development, promoting both academic and interpersonal success.

In contrast, strengths such as prudence, forgiveness, and hope are found at the bottom of the male graph, indicating lower use and less association with human flourishing. As with women, these strengths may not be as recognized or valued, suggesting a potential area for development and promotion.

Comparing both genders, it is observed that some strengths, such as leadership and love of learning, are important for both men and women in terms of their association with human flourishing. However, there are notable differences in other areas, such as vitality, which seems to be more significant for women, and creativity, which shows a greater connection with men. These differences highlight the importance of considering gender when promoting and developing character strengths, as needs and priorities may vary.

In this way, the graph provides a comprehensive view of how the use of different character strengths correlate with human flourishing, differentiated by gender. Strengths situated in the upper right quadrant, such as leadership and love of learning, seem to be especially beneficial for both genders. However, there are specific differences that should be considered when developing programs and strategies to promote well-being by using character strengths. This analysis underscores the need for a balanced and gender-adapted approach to the development of strengths toward the achievement of comprehensive and sustainable well-being.

15.5 Discussion

The findings of this study provide additional evidence on the positive relationship between the use of character strengths and human flourishing in Mexican university students. This research contributes to the growing body of knowledge in positive

psychology and positive education, offering valuable perspectives from the Latin American context. The research also sheds light on the differential relevance of certain strengths in relation to human flourishing. For example, the prominence of strengths such as leadership, courage, and vitality suggest that these qualities are strongly associated with flourishing, but also may have a particularly significant impact on the overall well-being of university students, an effect that remains to be tested in future studies. This finding is consistent with studies by Peterson and Park (2006) and Harzer and Ruch (2015), which highlight the importance of these strengths in academic and professional settings. This could lead to a reevaluation of how different strengths are prioritized and developed in educational and personal development programs.

Moreover, the observed differences between genders in terms of the use and connections of certain strengths raise interesting questions about how sociocultural factors may influence the development and expression of character strengths. This opens new lines of research on the interaction between gender, culture, and personal strengths in the context of human flourishing. For instance, the work of Lavy and Littman-Ovadia (2017) has shown that the application of character strengths can have a positive impact on academic performance and interpersonal relationships, which may vary by gender. This chapter presents several implications, theoretical, practical and methodological. By fostering human flourishing and the conscious use of character strengths, universities can give rise to graduates who are not only professionally successful but also contribute positively to society. These individuals, prepared with a solid sense of meaningful life and resilience, will be better trained to face social, economic, and environmental challenges, both locally and globally.

From a theoretical perspective, this study reinforces the connection between two fundamental concepts of positive psychology: character strengths and human flourishing. The results support the idea that the active use of personal strengths is closely linked to higher levels of well-being and personal fulfillment, which is consistent with the foundational theories of positive psychology and education.

Methodologically, this study highlights the convenience of using brief instruments to measure constructs such as the usage of character strengths. The validation of a short version of the strengths use scale offers a valuable tool for future researchers and practitioners, allowing for quick and efficient assessments without compromising the validity of results. Using a four-item instrument to measure character strengths has several benefits: shorter questionnaires can be completed much faster, which is ideal in situations where time is limited, and they reduce participant fatigue and boredom, thus improving the quality of responses. Additionally, shorter instruments typically have higher response rates and lower dropout rates, as participants are more likely to complete them.

From a practical standpoint, the findings of this study have significant implications for the design of educational and personal development programs in university settings. The strong correlation between the use of strengths and human flourishing suggests that educational institutions could benefit from incorporating strategies that encourage the recognition and active application of students' character strengths. Given that the VIA test is a free tool available in multiple languages, it

would be relevant for more educational institutions to promote among their students the understanding and utilization of their strengths, both in and out of the school context. The results also point to the importance of a personalized approach to strength development. Since different strengths show varying levels of association with human flourishing, student development programs could be designed to help students identify and cultivate those strengths that have a greater impact on their individual well-being.

Among the practical applications that can be derived from this study is the understanding that different strengths in students point to various ways in which they can achieve higher levels of human flourishing. Just as group tasks are favorable activities for students with strengths such as social intelligence and teamwork, tasks that allow for the application of zest and leadership can foster greater human flourishing in those who have these strengths as their signature qualities.

Furthermore, the identification of less utilized but potentially valuable strengths, such as prudence or appreciation of beauty, suggests areas of opportunity for the integral development of students. Universities could consider implementing specific activities and programs to foster these underexploited strengths. This is in line with the classical view of Aristotle, who considered that virtue was achieved through the practice and continuous development of positive habits (Aristóteles, 2018).

The use of a large and diverse sample of university students reinforces to some extent the generalization of findings and provides a solid foundation for future research in this field. Additionally, the focus on the use of strengths, rather than simply their presence, offers a more dynamic and applicable perspective on how character strengths can influence well-being. The incorporation of gender-differentiated analyses also highlights the importance of considering demographic variables in research on character strengths and human flourishing. This more nuanced approach can lead to a deeper and more contextualized understanding of how strengths operate in different populations.

15.6 Conclusion

This study provides significant insights into the relationship between the use of character strengths and human flourishing among Mexican university students. The findings underscore the importance of recognizing and actively applying personal character strengths to enhance well-being and personal fulfillment.

One of the key contributions of this research is the linkage of two highly relevant concepts within positive education: human flourishing and character strengths. By focusing on the usage of these strengths rather than merely their presence, the study offers a more dynamic and applicable perspective on how character strengths can influence well-being. This approach highlights the practical implications of fostering character strengths in educational settings.

The results indicate a positive relationship between the frequent use of character strengths and higher levels of human flourishing. Specific strengths such as

leadership, courage, and vitality were found to have a particularly strong association with flourishing. This suggests that these strengths could be priority areas for personal and academic development programs aimed at enhancing students' well-being.

The study also revealed interesting gender differences in the use and impact of character strengths. These differences underscore the importance of considering demographic factors in the design of strength-based interventions and educational programs. A tailored approach that takes into account the unique needs and priorities of different groups can lead to more effective and inclusive strategies for promoting well-being.

Future research should explore how the use of character strengths evolves over time and its long-term impact on human flourishing. Longitudinal studies could provide valuable insights into the stability and development of character strengths during university life and beyond. Additionally, targeted intervention programs aimed at promoting the use of character strengths could be developed and evaluated to further enhance students' well-being.

Expanding the study to different cultural contexts would also be beneficial to examine how cultural differences may influence the relationship between strengths usage and human flourishing. This could provide a more comprehensive understanding of the universality or cultural specificity of these constructs.

In conclusion, this study provides a solid foundation for future research in the fields of positive psychology and education. The findings highlight the importance of actively promoting the use of character strengths as a means of enhancing the well-being and flourishing of university students. The proposed directions for future research offer multiple avenues to expand and deepen our understanding of how character strengths can be cultivated and applied to improve the well-being, academic success, and personal development of university students. These lines of research have the potential to inform and shape educational policies and pedagogical practices that can significantly enhance students' holistic development, ultimately contributing to the creation of healthier and more prosperous societies.

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